
Threat Intelligence Report

Scattered Spider

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Executive Summary

This report provides an analytical overview of the threat actor known as the Scattered Spider, based on Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT), dark web intelligence sources, and publicly available reporting. The assessment examines observed behavior, including actor background, targeting patterns and victimology, tactics, techniques and procedures (TTPs), indicators of compromise (IOCs), and an overall evaluation of capability and intent. The objective of this report is to consolidate available intelligence into a structured threat profile that supports understanding of associated risk, operational behavior, and observed activity attributed to the actor.

Methodology

This report was developed using Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT) and dark web–derived information obtained from publicly accessible and reputable sources, including security research publications, news reporting, technical analyses, and indexed web content. Structured queries were used to identify relevant information relating to Scattered Spider infrastructure, behavioral patterns, and associated identifiers. All information was evaluated for credibility, relevance, and corroboration across multiple sources prior to inclusion. No unauthorized access, private datasets, or proprietary systems were used. The research was conducted using lawful and ethical methods for analytical and educational purposes.

Report Sections

- **Section 1: Threat Actor Overview**
- **Section 2: Targeting & Victimology**
- **Section 3: Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs)**
- **Section 4: Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)**
- **Section 5: Analytic Assessment**

Findings of Interest

Section 1: Threat Actor Overview

- Scattered Spider is a financially motivated cybercriminal collective operating within a broader Western-based cybercrime ecosystem, rather than a nation-state advanced persistent threat (APT). The group is loosely organized and associated with underground communities such as “The Comm,” and ALPHV/BlackCat ransomware gang, conducting intrusion, data theft, and extortion operations primarily through social engineering and identity compromise. **(Figure 1)**
- Active since at least 2022, Scattered Spider has emerged as a high-priority threat due to its ability to exploit enterprise identity systems at scale. The group demonstrates a decentralized structure with fluid membership and overlaps with other cybercriminal actors, relying heavily on tactics such as help desk impersonation, SIM swapping, and multi-factor authentication (MFA) bypass. **(Figure 2)**
- Scattered Spider has been linked to high-profile intrusions against major organizations, including MGM Resorts and Caesars Entertainment, further demonstrating its capability to achieve significant operational and financial impact through non-technical attack vectors.

Scattered Spider – Names by Organization

- **MITRE ATT&CK:** Scattered Spider (G1015) / UNC3944
- **Microsoft Threat Intelligence:** Octo Tempest
- **CrowdStrike:** Muddled Libra
- **Google / Mandiant:** UNC3944
- Additional reporting aliases: Oktapus (campaign association), Scatter Swine

Scattered Spider, also known as Muddled Libra, Octo Tempest, Scatter Swine and UNC3944, is a group of cybercriminals who specialize in using social-engineering tactics to trick companies into handing over user credentials and bypassing multifactor authentication, opening the door for the group to establish persistence, steal company data and demand ransom payments.

[Figure 1](#)

Scattered Spider, also referred to as UNC3944, Scatter Swine, and Muddled Libra, is a financially motivated threat actor group that has been active since May 2022. Scattered Spider has largely been observed targeting telecommunications and Business Process Outsourcing (BPO) organizations. However, recent activity indicates that this group has started targeting other sectors, including critical infrastructure organizations.

[Figure 2](#)

Section 2: Targeting & Victimology

- Scattered Spider selects targets based on accessibility of identity systems and potential for financial extortion, rather than geopolitical or intelligence value. The group prioritizes organizations where social engineering can be leveraged to gain initial access and escalate privileges.

Primary Targets:

- Large enterprises with complex identity environments (**Figure 3**)
- Hospitality and gaming (e.g., MGM Resorts, Caesars Entertainment) (**Figures 4 - 5**)
- Retail and e-commerce
- Telecommunications providers
- Technology / SaaS platforms

Victimology Pattern:

- Organizations with:
 - Help desk–driven password reset processes
 - Reliance on SMS or push-based MFA
 - Outsourced IT or support services
 - Large employee bases (increased social engineering surface)
 - High operational dependency on uptime (greater ransom leverage)
- **Analyst Comments:** Scattered Spider's targeting reflects an identity-first attack model, where victims are chosen based on access pathways and human vulnerabilities, not just industry or data type.

- **Victim Targeting:** Employs persistent targeting of high-value targets. They are a "big game hunter" and do not follow the general "crime of opportunity" we see with many other ransomware gangs.

Figure 3

Identity management vendor Okta confirmed that two of its customers, casino giants Caesars Entertainment and MGM Resorts, were compromised via social engineering attacks.

Figure 4

"Casinos around the world should be on heightened alert because ransomware groups love it when they get this kind of attention, so we will likely see copycats."

Figure 5

Section 3: Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs)

- Scattered Spider uses various techniques to break into systems, stay hidden, and steal data. (Figure 6)

Initial Access (how they get in)

- Phishing / social engineering (T1566) – tricking users into giving credentials
- Help desk impersonation (T1566) – calling IT to reset passwords or MFA
- MFA fatigue attacks (T1621) – sending repeated push requests until approved
- SIM swapping – taking over phone numbers to bypass MFA
- Used to gain access to accounts without exploiting software.

Execution (running commands)

- PowerShell (T1059.001)
- Command Shell (T1059.003)
- Used for system access and account control.

Persistence (staying inside)

- Valid Accounts (T1078) – maintaining access using compromised logins
- MFA re-enrollment (T1556) – adding attacker-controlled authentication
- Relies on account control instead of malware.

Credential Access (stealing logins)

- Credential harvesting (T1566) – phishing login pages
- MFA interception (T1556) – bypassing authentication methods
- Password resets via IT workflows (T1078 / T1566)
- Focused on taking over identities.

Defense Evasion (avoiding detection)

- Valid Accounts (T1078) – appearing as legitimate users
- Use of VPNs / proxies (T1090) – hiding real location
- Minimal malware usage / Blends in with normal activity.

Lateral Movement (moving through systems)

- Remote Desktop Protocol (RDP) (T1021.001)
- Trusted account access across systems (T1078)
- Uses legitimate access to expand within networks.

Exfiltration (stealing data)

- Exfiltration over web/cloud services (T1041)
- Data is removed using normal channels.

Scattered Spider relies heavily on social engineering, including impersonating IT and help-desk staff, to gain initial access, bypass multi-factor authentication (MFA), and compromise enterprise networks. The group has adapted its tooling to evade endpoint detection and response (EDR) defenses and used ransomware for financial gain. [3] [4] [5]

Figure 6

Section 4: Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

- Scattered Spider activity is mainly identified through behavioral and identity-based indicators, rather than traditional malware signatures.

Identity / Authentication Indicators:

- Unusual password reset requests via help desk
- Multiple MFA push notifications (MFA fatigue) **(Figure 7)**
- New MFA device added shortly after login changes
- Privilege escalation in identity systems (Okta, Azure AD) **(Figure 8)**

Login Behavior Indicators:

- Logins from new or unusual locations
- Use of residential IP addresses or VPNs
- Multiple failed logins followed by success

Network Indicators:

- Remote access via RDP from unfamiliar devices (**T1021.001**)
- Access through proxies or anonymization tools (**T1090**)

Tool / System Indicators:

Unusual use of:

- PowerShell (**T1059.001**)
- Remote admin tools and cloud portals

Identity management vendor Okta had previously disclosed that four unnamed customers had fallen victim to a social engineering campaign that affected victims' MFA protections.

Figure 7

Common targets include:

- VMware vCenter and ESXi virtualization environments
- Cloud identity providers (Azure AD/Entra ID, AWS IAM, Google Cloud Identity, Okta)
- Privileged access management systems and administrative accounts
- VPN and remote access solutions
- Backup and recovery systems
- Help desk and IT support personnel

Figure 8

Section 5: Analytic Assessment

- Scattered Spider is assessed as a highly capable financially motivated cybercriminal collective operating within a broader Western-based cybercrime ecosystem. The group has no confirmed evidence of state-directed espionage activity (**Figures 9 - 11**)
- The actor focuses primarily on financial theft and data extortion, using advanced social engineering and identity compromise techniques to gain access to enterprise environments. Its operations demonstrate strong adaptability, particularly in bypassing multi-factor authentication and exploiting help desk processes.
- **Threat Level: High** - Based on its ability to consistently compromise large enterprises, bypass identity controls, and conduct high-impact extortion campaigns. The group remains a significant risk due to its evolving tactics, decentralized structure, and effectiveness in targeting identity systems rather than technical vulnerabilities.

Scattered Spider has quickly become one of the internet's more prolific and dangerous [ransomware groups](#) in the past few years. This crew has moved from an obscure corner of cybercrime into the center of the boardroom conversation, and not because they're the most technically advanced adversaries out there.

It's because they're smart enough to exploit the one vulnerability too many companies still ignore: trust.

[Figure 9](#)

Scattered Spider, aka **UNC3944, Octo Tempest, Oktapus, Muddled Libra, and Scatter Swine**, is one of the most dangerous and adaptive financially motivated groups in the cyber threat landscape in 2025.

[Figure 10](#)

What makes this group especially dangerous is its mix of patient planning and sudden escalation. Scattered Spider doesn't just rely on stolen credentials—it spends time gathering intel on its targets, often combining social media research with public breach data to impersonate people with scary accuracy. This kind of hybrid threat, blending Social engineering techniques with cloud infrastructure sabotage, can fly under the radar until it's too late.

[Figure 11](#)

Limitations of Open Source (OS) Information

This report is based solely on publicly available open-source intelligence (OSINT). The information presented is subject to limitations inherent in open-source collection, including potential gaps in availability, completeness, and timeliness of data at the time of analysis. While efforts are made to ensure accuracy and relevance, some relevant information may not be publicly accessible or may not be captured during the collection process. As such, findings should be interpreted as analytical assessments based on available data rather than exhaustive or definitive intelligence.

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